



Trillian

If you have friends on more than one of the IM networks, and currently shuffle between clients to chat with them, consider a unified messaging client. Trillian is an all-in-one messenger, which supports ICQ, MSN, AIM and Yahoo!, with a sleek skinable interface. You will need to register with those networks before you can use any of them with Trillian.

one IM that the entire group uses to remain connected. Interoperability, or better still, a common standard, would greatly increase the value of the entire IM community, making the whole greater than the sum of its parts, so to speak.

One of the key benefits of online communication is presence. The fact that you can see the status of your contacts online lets you know whether they are contactable, and if they are, the effort required to contact them is minimal. This ease of use, combined with the impersonality of text messaging, tends to remove inhibitions and formalities, and allows for a more open and free exchange. Whilst presence is cool for your friends, it's a valuable asset for any business. Within the organization, a lot of time is saved because employees don't have to walk across to another department to ask a question, or dial an extension to find the concerned person not at her desk.

Accessibility to your clients is also greatly increased. How, you ask? It is truly impractical to have every client on your ICQ, or MSN contact list. So, what you can do is use one of ICQ's free services that run off your Web site. The most basic of these is the Online Status indicator that tells your visitors whether you are online, or offline. If you add your ICQ number, they can put you on their contact list, and you can begin conversing to solve the client's problem, or answer a query. Yahoo! Messenger users can also add their online status to their Web pages.

Every Web site has a page with contact details so that the creator, or company, can be contacted. This page can contain your online status along with a link, to take the visitor to your Unified Messaging Center on ICQ's servers (<http://www.icq.com/ICQ#>), from where the visitor will find several ways to contact you immediately—you can be contacted directly on ICQ, the visitor can add you to their contact list, or you can even be contacted on your mobile phone via SMS. Providing such a service will be a big boost to your business. Just imagine someone visiting your Web site and not buying something because he is sceptical, or needs some more information about the product. The ability to communicate with clients lets

you answer queries, and convince them of your product. Though this has not yet been quantified, IM within the organisation can improve productivity.

There are some problems with IM in the office environment though. By far, the largest concern is security. Consumer IM applications send plain text messages, and are very vulnerable to eavesdropping. If IM is to become a viable communication medium in the corporate world, this issue must be addressed. When messages go out of the local network and onto the Internet, they open up security holes in the firewall—opening it to attack. These concerns can be addressed by deploying a company-wide standard, secure IM. Yahoo offers a secure IM, called Yahoo! Messenger Enterprise Edition. It has all the features of the standard Yahoo! Messenger, and boasts of additional ones that are targeted at the managed business network such as 128-bit encrypted messaging, integrated logging and archiving of messages, local administrative control, authentication against the company's corporate directory, and screen names using the employee's existing e-mail address.

Another problem is that IMs lend themselves nicely to purposes other than official business. Chatting with friends outside the organisation about yesterday's cricket match would be a waste of

info

IDC expects there will be 506 million IM users by 2006, of which, nearly half will be business users

Status Indicators - ICQ & Yahoo

Adding a status indicator to your Web site involves adding some HTML code into the Web pages where you want your status displayed.

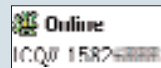
ICQ's basic status indicator does not link back to anything, so you can do two things to get surfers to reach you when you're online. The first is to write your ICQ number beside the status indicator, so that they can add you to their contact list. The other way is to make the status indicator link back to your Unified Messaging Center on ICQ's Web site. The sample code below does both of these. Don't forget to replace 'your_icq_number' in all three places.

```
<a
href="http://www.icq.com/your_icq_number">


```
q='your_icq_number'&img=21" border=0>

ICQ# 'your_icq_number'
```


```



Visit <http://www.icq.com/features/web/indicator.html> for more styles of indicators. If users can't see your online status go to **Main > Security & Privacy Permissions > General**, and click the Web Aware checkbox.

Yahoo makes better use of the status indicator by linking to a page that lets your visitor send you a message and even get a reply through a Web-based Java version of Yahoo! Messenger. However, it's in the early stages, and should get better sooner than later. You should also add your Yahoo! e-mail ID, just in case. Again, replace your_yahoo_id in all three places in the

code given below.

```
<a
href="http://edit.yahoo.com/config/send_webmesg?.target='your_yahoo_id'&.src=pg">


```



What about MSN? Microsoft does not provide any way of putting your status on your Web site. You could try a free service that offers to do so at www.onlinestatus.org. They have a few servers running, but the code on your Web page can only link to any one of them. When that server goes down, so does the status indicator.